



MONTHLY UPDATE

Gambia: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-08 • 49 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • FINANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • TECHNOLOGY • CAPACITY • INCLUSION • DATA • GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Identity and elections were the month's two threads. The government [launched the first phase of the new biometric national identity card](#), publishing a [phased rollout calendar and a fee](#), and published its first unified land policy, which mandates a [digitalised national land administration system and a centralised land information system](#).

The electoral register is contested. Opposition parties put it to the commission that [212,095 supplementary registrations had been announced against 179,445 records on the data distributed to them](#), and the [commission's chairman gave a public assurance on the register's credibility](#) without a reconciled figure being published. Elsewhere the civil servant and pensioner verification exercise [was suspended up-country over technical difficulties](#), the press union [reported the access-to-information law still largely unimplemented](#), and Senegal and Gambia [held the first steering-committee session of their digital cooperation memorandum at Banjul on 29 August](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The policy shelf was restocked, with an unusually frank admission attached. The Gambia [validated a ten-year science, technology and innovation policy for 2027-2035 after its minister conceded the previous one achieved none of its objectives](#). A minister saying so on the record is worth more than the policy document itself, because it dates the failure the successor has to avoid. Cabinet separately [approved a bill to establish a national research, development and innovation council](#); the council does not yet exist.

Legislation and regulation

An Act already in force showed what passing one is worth on its own: the press union reported on 7 August that [most public institutions have yet to appoint the information officers the Access to Information Act requires, and that twenty-one-day requests go unanswered](#). No government response, compliance count or enforcement action is on record. The Communications Bill 2025, meanwhile, stayed in committee. Two Assembly committees [met the Press Union and the Media Council on 18 July 2026](#); the Union set out the media laws it wants repealed alongside the bill, and members said they could take stakeholder views into committee but not debate it publicly.

A second instrument was validated on [31 July 2026: the State Intelligence Service Bill](#), at a workshop attended by the National Security Adviser, the Chief of Defence Staff, the Assembly's defence committee and civil society. The Adviser said the draft prohibits torture, unlawful detention and political targeting, requires judicial warrants and oversight for intrusive measures, and gives the Assembly review of the Service's budgets. Its threat frame is

cybercrime, espionage, disinformation and organised crime, so it is where Gambian communications interception would sit. The text is not held, the Bill has not been tabled, and it does not appear in the Assembly's bills library, checked 2026-08-08.

Data protection

The body that carries both of the country's information statutes surfaced in the record for the first time this window, and it surfaced as a recipient of support rather than as a regulator acting. The Information Commission, responsible for the Access to Information Act 2021 and the Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025, is [receiving UNFPA-funded support under the Peacebuilding Fund's Public Accountability Project to build a communication strategy raising public awareness of both statutes](#). No budget, staffing, caseload or enforcement record for the commission is held, and awareness-raising support is not evidence of capacity to enforce.

Regional collaboration

The revenue authority [hosted the seventh ATAF Heads of Tax Administrations Master Class in Banjul on 23-24 July 2026](#). The Forum's executive secretary argued from Rwanda, Kenya and Morocco that digital systems deliver only alongside governance reform — "technology alone collects nothing" — and [pressed for a united African position at the United Nations](#).

The bilateral channel that bears on connectivity moved from signature to work. The June 2026 telecommunications and digital-economy memorandum with Senegal [went into implementation around four priorities — connectivity, cybersecurity, skills and digital transformation — with the Senegalese telecommunications and digital minister travelling to Banjul to agree the first joint work, the two regulators having separately deepened cooperation on frequency coordination, service quality and cross-border roaming](#). The structural case for it is the country's own: a limited terrestrial fibre build and dependence on a single submarine cable for international access, with only limited terrestrial redundancy through Senegal. No work programme, budget or timetable is published. That work took its first steering-committee session at [Banjul on 29 August 2026](#), where the four priorities were settled as infrastructure and interoperability, cyber resilience, capacity building and regulatory harmonisation, with rural electronic-government access named among them. No timetable, budget or named deliverable is attached to any of the four.

Standards

The standards bureau's position was restated from both ends this month. Its director general put adoptions at [around 500 standards, alongside membership of the African standards organisation](#), while the international body's own profile records the bureau as a [Correspondent member without a vote at the standards and electrotechnical organisations, and the country's technical-barriers enquiry point](#). A correspondent member may adopt standards; it does not help make them.

Finance

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure

The finance ministry gave its fullest account yet of what digitalised collection has recovered. On [30 July 2026 the minister said total tax collected rose from D11 billion in 2022 to D25 billion in 2025](#), with rate rises only on gambling, alcohol and tobacco, and credited a named stack running from ASYCUDA World and digital excise stamps to fuel marking, rental tax digitalisation and electronic invoicing. He read reforms lifting collections by more than 100% as evidence of prior leakage rather than of under-taxation, and said tax to GDP moved from [9% in 2022 to 13% in 2025](#). It is an attribution by the collecting side, not an evaluation.

Four days later the revenue authority [published a 2026 target of D27.5 billion](#) — the first forward number in the series, and the first testable one. The implied step from 2025 is about a tenth, far below the run rate the attribution rests on.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The country renumbered its mobile network. [The transition to nine-digit numbers began on 4 September 2026, existing numbers taking a two-digit operator prefix — 87 for Africell, 83 for QCell and 86 for Comium; Gamcel numbers are not affected in this phase and keep their seven digits.](#) The numbering plan instrument is not published, and nothing states when the deferred operator joins.

Data Storage

The first private data centre was inaugurated on 29 April 2026 and announced from the State House, the [operator claiming it as the country's first](#). No capacity, occupancy or certification figure accompanies the claim, which leaves the country's private hosting estate established in existence and unmeasured in every other respect.

Energy

The power the digital estate runs on was explained and priced in the same month. The utility put the year's worst outages down to [ageing generating units and spare parts taking six to seven months to import, promising relief within a fortnight](#); a lender's public finance review puts [tariffs at an average US\\$0.21 a kilowatt-hour, among the highest globally, driven by weak utility financial performance with subsidies found misdirected](#). The target above both is now traceable to its instrument: a [draft national compact seeking US\\$552m to reach 100% access by 2030, unsigned and unfunded](#).

DPI

Data Exchange

The first register link to be agreed is between education and health rather than between the registers the interoperability indicator counts. [A memorandum connects the education and health information systems to flag vulnerable children and verify enrolment.](#) It is a memorandum rather than a live interface, and the project's own indicator for register interoperability still stands at zero.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The [National Identity Management System went live on 1 July 2026](#), issuing GAM ID cards on the spot, with nationwide enrolment from 4 August 2026. On 7 August the interior ministry [began a nationwide rollout of new ten-year biometric national identity cards, with registration opening simultaneously at six centres](#), produced with a Ghana-based supplier. No enrolment or issuance figure has been published since launch, so the system's reach is unestablished.

The rollout got the calendar the base had been missing. The government [published the phased schedule and fee structure: registration extends to Sibanor and Jarra Soma on 7 September, to Barra, Kerewan, Farafenni and Kaur on 11 September and to Janjanbureh, Basse and Fatoto on 21 September, with a first-time card at D450 waived during the rollout for holders of a valid immigration department card.](#) An applicant with no passport, birth certificate or prior document must be vouched for by both the Alkalo and the Seyfo of their place of residence.

What the identity system replaced is now documented from two sides, and the backfill matters more than the launch. A [lender diagnostic finds fragmented mandates, no universal coverage and weak interoperability across the identity estate](#), and a newspaper account describes a [processing centre in Kanifing shut when its electricity bill went unpaid, on a foreign-run biometric system in place since 2018 at a D450 fee](#). Against that, the system [went live on 29 June 2026 with the President as its first enrollee, under a public-private partnership between the interior ministry and the card supplier](#).

Digital Payments and Fintech

The country appears here in a survey of other people's pilots rather than in an account of its own. A UN development agency [names a wallet pilot in the Gambia among blockchain-based payment-distribution schemes said to cut distribution costs from about 10% to as little as 2%](#). The cost figure is the agency's own and describes its portfolio rather than this pilot; no caseload, value distributed or evaluation is held for the Gambian instance.

Registries

The country published its first unified land policy, and it is the month's clearest statement of intent about a public register. The [National Land Policy 2026-2035 mandates a digitalised National Land Administration System, a centralised Land Information System and digitised land registration](#), alongside new Certificates of Customary Ownership, and carries a costed ten-year implementation roadmap. It is a mandate rather than a build: no supplier, budget line, custodian or start date is stated for either system, and no data-protection provision for the land record is reported — in a year in which the Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025 came into force.

A register the country already runs was disputed in the same week. Opposition parties put it to the electoral commission that [212,095 supplementary registrations had been announced against 179,445 records on the data distributed to them](#), a gap the commission attributed to unverified processing outputs. No reconciled figure has been published, and a presidential election is due this year.

Two registers moved from intention to a dated position. The land system has consultants [drafting a land information system with the draft due at the end of September 2026, the lands minister putting land disputes at 62% of court cases](#) — which is worth reading against what a parliamentary committee found a year earlier: [leases taking up to five years, no land policy behind laws dating from the 1990s, and the survey department down to two of its eight vehicles](#). And the tax system moved from planned to contracted: a [US\\$7.27m, 24-month contract signed on 7 October 2025 on lender funding](#), with the revenue authority since [briefing manufacturers ahead of rollout and pledging fully online filing](#).

Sectoral management information systems

The month's one management system came from outside government. The Gambia Red Cross Society [launched a Volunteer and Membership Management System at its Kanifing headquarters on 31 August 2026, replacing branch paper registers with one record covering registration, profiling, branch assignment, validation, deployment and direct communication](#), its secretary-general putting the cost of the paper system as delay in emergencies. No volunteer count, cost, funder or vendor is published.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The revenue authority said on [30 July 2026 that South African and Rwandan customs officials will study its digital excise tax stamp](#), after officials from Nigeria, Senegal and Sierra Leone; the commissioner general attached to it [a claimed 95% reduction in smuggling of excisable goods](#), a figure with no method, made by the authority whose system is being studied. The finance ministry also [named a planned Integrated Tax Administration System](#), with no procurement, vendor or timetable.

The trade ministry said on [4 August 2026](#) that a [Digital Single Window Business Registration System](#) is being [finalised](#), with no launch date.

The electoral commission's digitalisation produced its first published contest figure. At a stakeholders' forum on 7 August the chief electoral officer disclosed [1,600 objections filed against the 2026 supplementary voter roll](#), on eligibility and residency, now before Revising Court Magistrates ahead of the provisional register being merged with the 2021 Voter Register. No denominator of supplementary registrations, no outcome of the hearings and no merged register total is held.

Technology

Innovation ecosystem

The hub estate is listed rather than surveyed. [Four hubs appear in a continental directory](#) — a [disruptive lab](#), a [technology company](#), a [startup incubator](#) and a [co-working network](#), alongside a [developer group chapter in the capital reporting about 992 members and running artificial-intelligence and civic-technology meetups](#). No membership, funding, cohort or survival figure is published for any of them, so what the base holds is a count of names.

Capacity

Training and skills

The national university's technology school [offers three bachelor's degrees and six-month diplomas in artificial intelligence, cybersecurity and data science](#), the widest named provision the base holds. It follows the President's June direction to the applied science university to [fast-track a second phase including a college of computer engineering](#).

Inclusion

Digital divides

The schools' side of the divide has a figure for the first time, and it is small: [13.2% of schools have internet available for teaching, across a system of 830,895 learners](#), on the education ministry's own statistics summary. No breakdown by level, region or school type comes with it — but it is the denominator every education-technology programme in this report has been running without.

Data

Open data

One measured position moved into the record. The Gambia [ranked third in sub-Saharan Africa on budget transparency in the 2025 open budget survey](#). Budget transparency and open data are different things: the survey measures what a government publishes about its own spending, and the record held still carries no dataset count or portal for The Gambia.

Geopolitics

China activities

Chinese engagement remained visible as training rather than infrastructure. The embassy [announced twenty-five further Gambians travelling to China in September under ministry grants, with a vocational workshop and a laboratory planned](#). The broadband and fifth-generation work the ambassador [named in 2023](#) still carries no contract, value or date. A second channel opened at official level: on a visit to Guizhou University the country's permanent representative in Geneva [announced four initiatives](#) – the Guizhou Provincial Big Data Laboratory as a data-governance research centre for the UN science and technology commission, a national data laboratory in The Gambia replicating it, scholarships in big data and artificial-intelligence governance, and a joint summer school. They are announcements, not agreements: no text, funding or timetable is held, and none is a Gambian government instrument.

EU activities

The Commission's country page sets the frame at [EUR 193m of grants for 2021-2027, with digitalisation named as one clause under jobs and growth](#), so the digital share remains unstated. The delivered items are smaller and dated: a [EUR 493,346 platform tracking 237 national development plan indicators](#) and the [fingerprint identification system launched in May](#).

Gulf/UAE activities

Gulf involvement is now on the record in two forms, neither carrying a figure. The Islamic Development Bank's own sector page records it [financing the regional fibre backbone reaching The Gambia alongside two other lenders, with no date or sum given](#), and a Bahraini firm's [January memorandum with the regulator offers a free critical-infrastructure security tier with no value or duration stated](#).

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